

How can you refer to the same component in strategy, planning and implementation work if people call them by different names?

In discussions about strategy, planning, implementation, and reporting, there can be considerable confusion about exactly what is being referred to by some of the terms being used. Just as confusingly, the same term is also sometimes used to describe things that are actually conceptually different. This is because people with different backgrounds and from different disciplines are involved in this type of work.

Terminological confusion can result in wasted time during such discussions. This happens when different people are not clear about what a particular term means. In some cases, they may be too embarrassed to ask because they do not want to reveal the fact that they are unclear as to the meaning of a term. In other cases, there may not be enough time during a busy meeting for someone to explain a term to them.

So two people can end up using the same term to mean different things, or different terms to mean the same thing, and this can lead to confusion and frustration. You can also get the same problem occurring in documents such as evaluation plans and Requests for Proposals (RFPs) where readers interpret terms differently from how the author intended them to be interpreted.

The Strategy and Outcomes Systems Terminology Tool (D2) can be used to clarify terminology when different people are using different technical terms for differing parts of the strategy, planning, implementation and reporting process. By simply pointing to the relevant component within the tool, two people who are using different terms for the same thing can immediately see that they are talking about the same component.

This tool can also be included in documentation such as Requests for Proposals (RFPs) and descriptions of planning processes to help people use standard terminology when they interact with central agencies, funders, evaluation commissioners or others.